adds to her mystique. Whether she is loved or hated, Mayawati has been one of the most powerful chief ministers of the past two decades.[13]

Perhaps even more interestingly, in West Bengal, a poor state in India's northeast where cosmopolitan Calcutta is located, a modest folk leader named Mamata Banerjee succeeded in May 2011 in ousting the Communist Party, which had held power for thirty-four years. Mamata, as everyone calls her, lives a frugal life with her mother and is clearly a populist icon in West Bengal. Her previous stint as national railways minister was not particularly successful, and many question whether she has a real agenda for reviving Bengal's economy despite nearly a decade in office. Regardless, she is a symbol of fearlessness to many Indians, men as well as women, for having survived imprisonment and physical abuse at the hands of the former ruling Communist Party.

Indian women are slowly breaking the political glass ceiling in other ways. For five years, from 2014 to 2019, Sushma Swaraj served as India's minister of external affairs, and in September 2017, Nirmala Sitharaman became the country's first independently appointed female minister of defense, then succeeding to the crucial post of Minister of Finance in 2019.[14] Two of India's ambassadors to the United States were women, serving consecutively from 2009 to 2013. Yet the Gandhis, Mamatas, and Mayawatis are the exception, no matter how prominent they are. Out of 790 seats in the national parliament, only 63 were held by female parliamentarians in 2017, while in 2014, women held just under 12 percent.[15] This means India ranks behind Afghanistan, Bangladesh, Pakistan, and Nepal in female parliamentarians, despite having elected a female head of state, Indira Gandhi, in 1966, the second country in the world to do so.

Beyond female politicians, Indian women increasingly appear in the spotlight. India's Bollywood leading ladies are everywhere, and many seem more popular than their male costars. Indian TV annually reports from Cannes, for example, where superstar Aishwarya Rai, among others, regularly takes the red carpet. As in any country, the life of an international celebrity like Rai is a poor yardstick by which to measure the lives of ordinary women, or men, for that matter. Yet even